

ASSAULT ON AMERICA



Associated Press
A jetliner heads for one of the World Trade Center towers in New York on Tuesday.

Early evidence suggests bin Laden devised attacks

BY JOHN WALCOTT
AND WARREN P. STROBEL
Knight Ridder Tribune

U.S. intelligence agencies gathered initial evidence that “strongly points” to terrorist mastermind Osama bin Laden for the devastating attacks Tuesday on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon, senior U.S. officials said.

The terrorists struck at the symbols of American financial and military might, using hijacked jetliners as suicide missiles to level the twin towers of the World Trade Center in New York City and blast into the Pentagon.

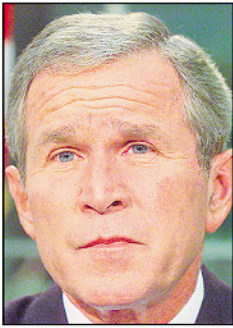
A somber President Bush vowed to a shocked nation Tuesday night to find the terrorists who assaulted America and “bring them to justice.”

One U.S. official said that the information was “not absolutely definitive yet,” but that bin Laden and possibly allies outside his al-Qaeda organization were now “at the top of the list of suspects” responsible for the bloodiest terror attack in U.S. history.

“There’s nothing hard, but he’s one of a very few people who would want to do this and who also has access to the tools and the kind of people you need to do this,” said a senior intelligence official who requested anonymity.

At the same time, however, other groups are not being ruled out, a second well-placed source said. Bin Laden agents also might have worked with other groups, as is now suspected in last year’s attack on the USS Cole in Yemen.

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“I pray they will be comforted by a power greater than any of us, spoken through the ages in Psalm 23. ‘Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I fear no evil for you are with me.’”

P R E S I D E N T
B U S H



Associated Press
Smoke, flames and debris erupt from one of the World Trade Center towers as an airliner strikes it Tuesday. The first tower already was burning after being struck by another airliner. Both towers later collapsed.



Associated Press
Two women hold onto each other as they watch the World Trade Center burn Tuesday morning in New York.

Reports of life amid rubble encourage recovery efforts

■ But paramedics are told, “Once the smoke clears, it’s going to be massive bodies.”

Eagle news services

As night fell, New York City and Washington moved past the nightmarish scenes of destruction and braced for more pain: picking through the rubble for thousands of dead or injured victims.

Crews began heading into ground zero of the terrorist attacks on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon to search for survivors

and recover bodies. New York City’s downtown area was cordoned off, and a huge rescue effort was under way. Gov. George Pataki mobilized the National Guard to help, and hundreds of volunteers and medical workers converged on triage centers, offering services and blood.

One man caught under the rubble used his cell phone to reach family in Pennsylvania with a plea for help.

“She received a call from him saying he was still trapped under the World Trade Center. He gave specific directions and said he was there along with two New York City sergeants,” said Brian Jones,

911 coordinator in Allegheny County. The message was passed to New York authorities.

New York City Mayor Rudy Giuliani said late Tuesday night that there still are some people alive in the World Trade Center. But rescuers expressed enormous frustration, saying that every time they prodded the rubble, they risked causing further damage.

“We were on top of the rubble,” firefighter Joe Miller said. “We thought we heard voices. But I don’t know how we could get to them.”

Paramedics waiting to be sent

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INSIDE

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Coping through prayer: Wichitans turn to faith to deal with the tragedy. **9A**

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Chenoweth sees attack: Ex-Jayhawk “still shaking” hours after crash. **1D**



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